Fewer cases, more crime

Bangladesh Police crime statistics · January 2019 – September 2026 · 93 months · 17 police units

PERIOD: All years | FROM: Jan 2019 | TO: Sep 2026 | POLICE UNITS: All units (national) | CRIME HEADS: Dacoity, Robbery, Murd...

Read the story ↓

TOTALS FOR YOUR SELECTION

Total cases, Jan 2019 – Sep 2026	Reported crime (excl. recovery)	Recovery cases (police-initiated)	4 selected crime heads
1,516,124	**898,108**	**618,016**	**44,581**

WHAT CHANGED IN YOUR SELECTION

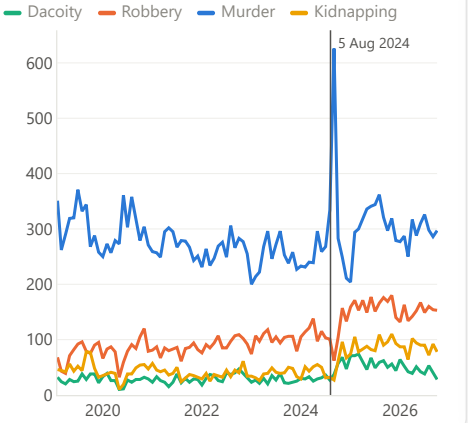
−41.0% fall in recorded cases from July to August 2024

−5.6% recorded cases, 24 months after vs 24 months before August 2024; reported crime +6.7%

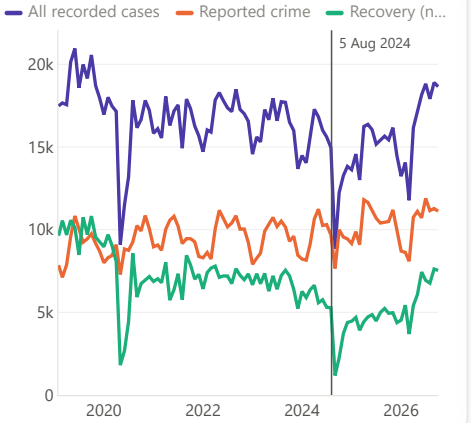
+111.5% kidnapping, 24 months after vs 24 months before August 2024

+4.7% murder once backlog filings are removed (not significant), against +15.0% raw

Selected heads, month by month

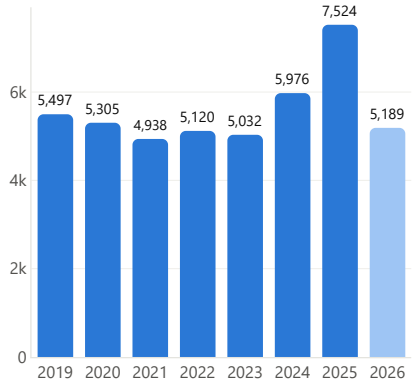


All cases: reported crime vs police-initiated rec...



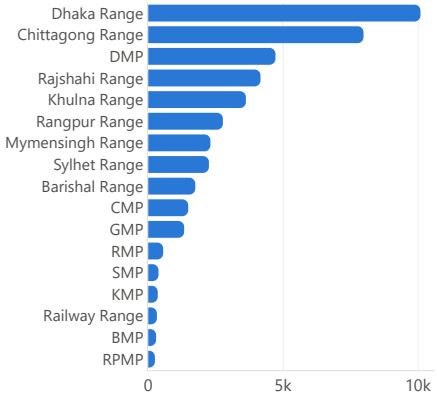
Selected heads, year by year

Lighter bar: year with fewer months selected



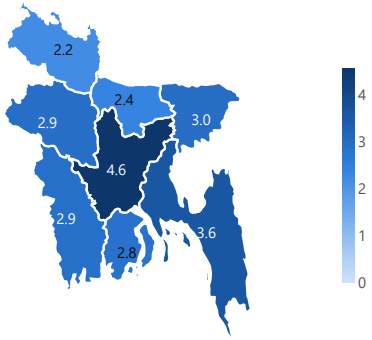
Selected heads by police unit

Highlighted: the units you picked

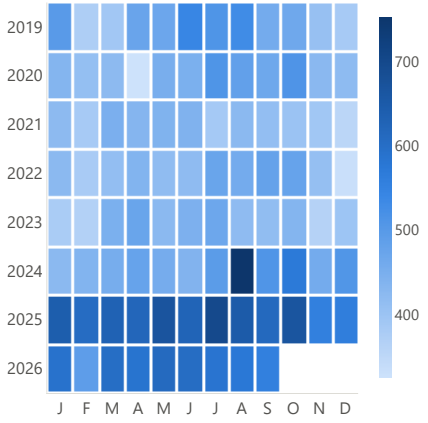


Selected heads per 100,000 people a year

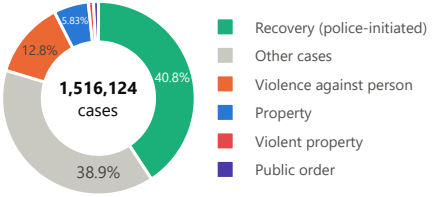
By division; railway police not mapped



Selected heads by calendar month

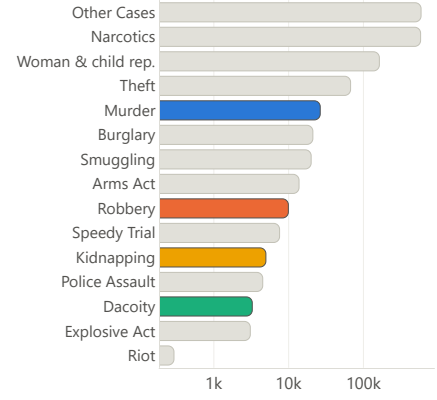


Share of all cases by crime family



Every crime head (log scale)

Coloured: the heads you picked



DATA STORY

Bangladesh's police are recording fewer cases. Victims are reporting more crime.

In the two years after the government fell on 5 August 2024, the police recorded 6% fewer cases a month than in the two years before. The drop is in police searches and seizures, which fell 24%. Victims, meanwhile, reported more crime: kidnapping rose 112%, dacoity 85% and robbery 48%.

Every month, Bangladesh Police Headquarters publishes a table of the cases its units recorded: one row for each of the 17 police units, one column for each type of case. We digitised all 93 tables from January 2019 to September 2026 and merged them into one dataset of 1,516,124 cases. Read together, they tell two stories at once: what happened to crime, and what happened to policing.

A country in numbers

Most of what the police count is not crime that someone reported. It is crime the police went looking for.

The 1,516,124 cases fall into two families of almost equal size. *Reported crime* (898,108 cases) is led by the catch-all “other cases” and by woman and child repression, which alone is 18.2% of reported crime. *Recovery cases* (618,016, 40.8% of the total) are police-initiated seizures; narcotics alone are 38.3% of everything recorded. Murder, the crime that dominates headlines, is 26,440 cases, 1.7% of the total. Click a ring to zoom into a family.

What gets counted

Inner ring: crime family; outer ring: crime head. Share of all cases, Jan 2019 – Sep 2026.

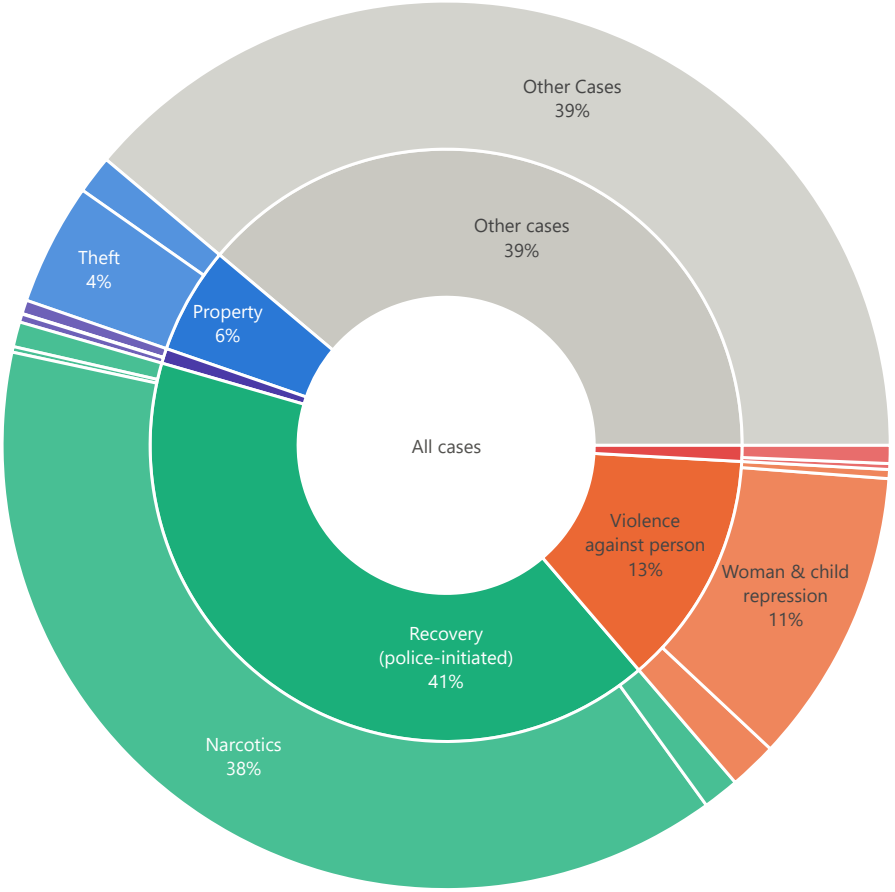


Chart data (CSV)

Because the two families move in opposite directions, the national total misleads on its own. Reported crime (orange) has a yearly rhythm and a gentle upward drift; recovery cases (aqua) fell by about half. Their sum (violet) peaked at 20,955 in May 2019 and inherits the decline of the second family. Two months stand out: April 2020 (9,098 cases), when the COVID-19 shutdown emptied the streets, and August 2024 (8,833), the lowest in the series.

The national total hides two opposite currents

Monthly cases. Thin lines: monthly values; thick lines: 3-month centred mean.

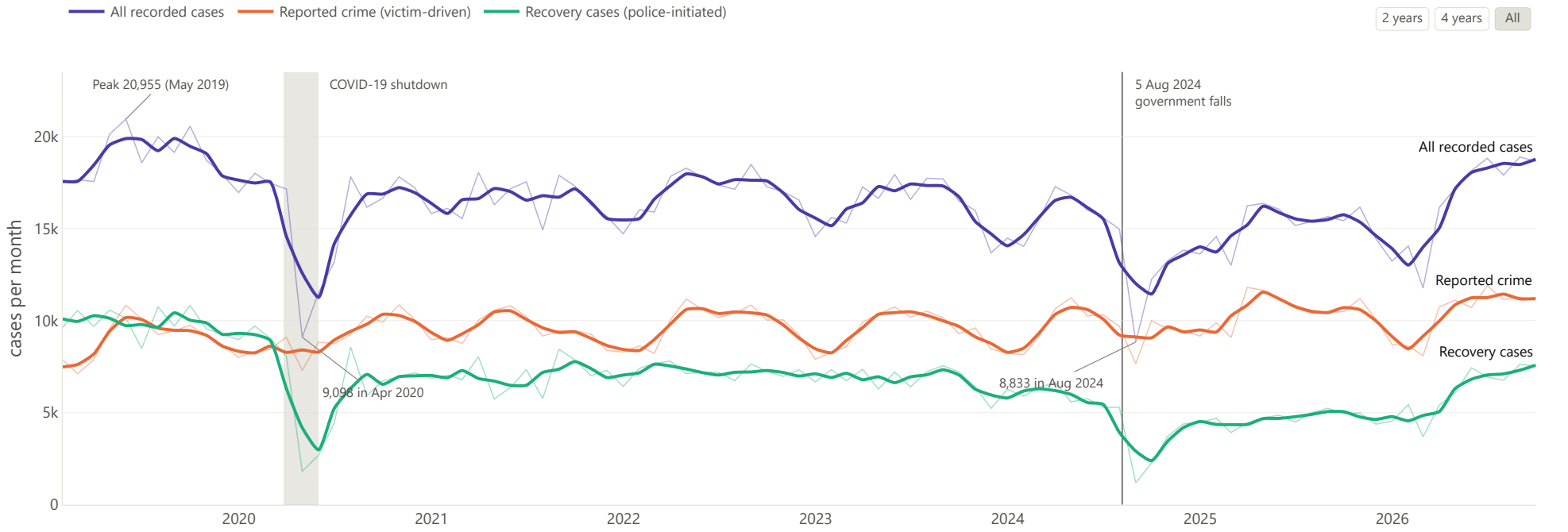


Chart data (CSV)

The rhythm of an ordinary year

Crime in Bangladesh has a calendar: it climbs from February to a peak in May and June and falls to its lowest point in December.

Reported crime peaks in May and bottoms out in December, a swing of about 28% between the strongest and weakest months; its STL seasonal strength is 0.55 on a 0–1 scale. Switch the heatmap to recovery cases and the rhythm disappears, while the outlined August 2024 cell turns pale.

Calendar of crime: May peaks, December lulls, and the August 2024 hole

Monthly national cases (thousands for large series). Outlined cell: August 2024. Blank: not yet published.

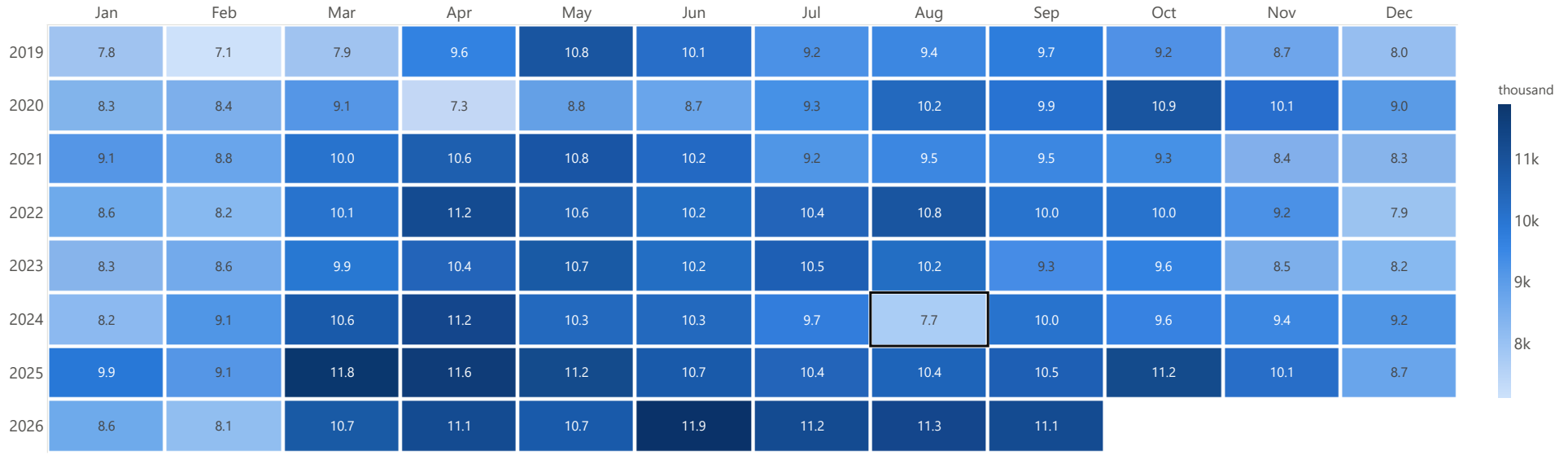


Chart data (CSV)

Each crime has its own season. Woman and child repression rises from March and stays high until October; murder peaks in July; burglary and theft peak in August and September, the lean season before the main rice harvest. The averages use normal years only, so the shocks of 2020 and 2024 do not distort them; switch to all years to see how much those shocks move the profile.

Every crime has a season

Average month-of-year index (each year's monthly mean = 100) with 95% confidence band.

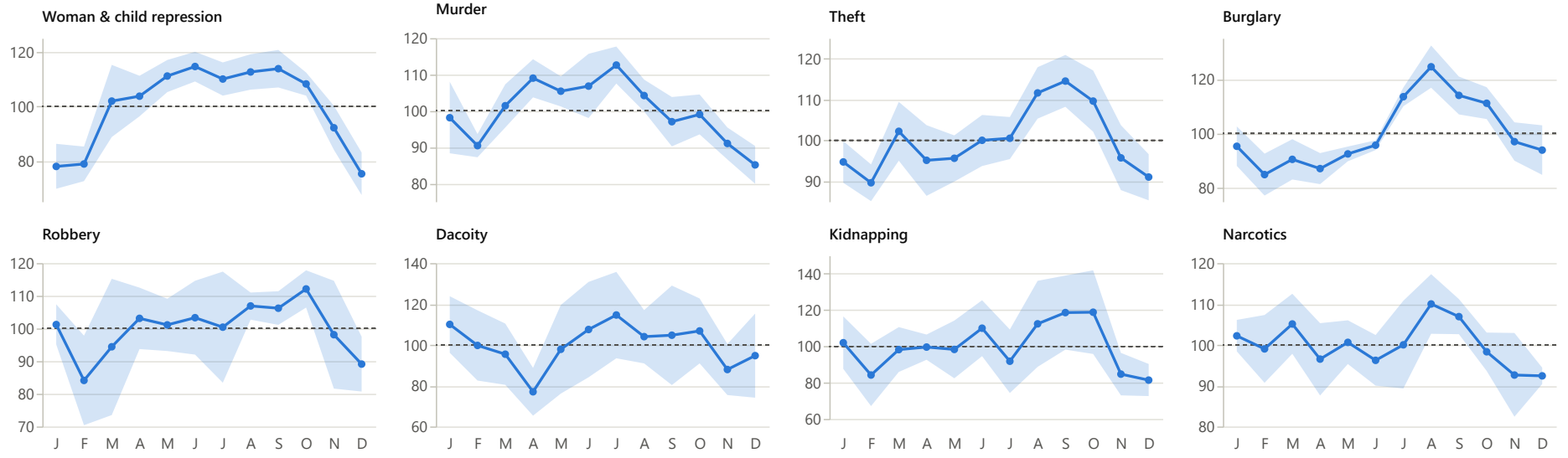


Chart data (CSV)

The STL decomposition separates trend, season and shock. Pick any series to see its trend step after August 2024 and the residual shocks of the lockdown months.

Under the noise: trend, season and shock

Robust STL decomposition (period 12) of log monthly cases; seasonal and residual shown as % effects. Red dots: shocks above 15%.

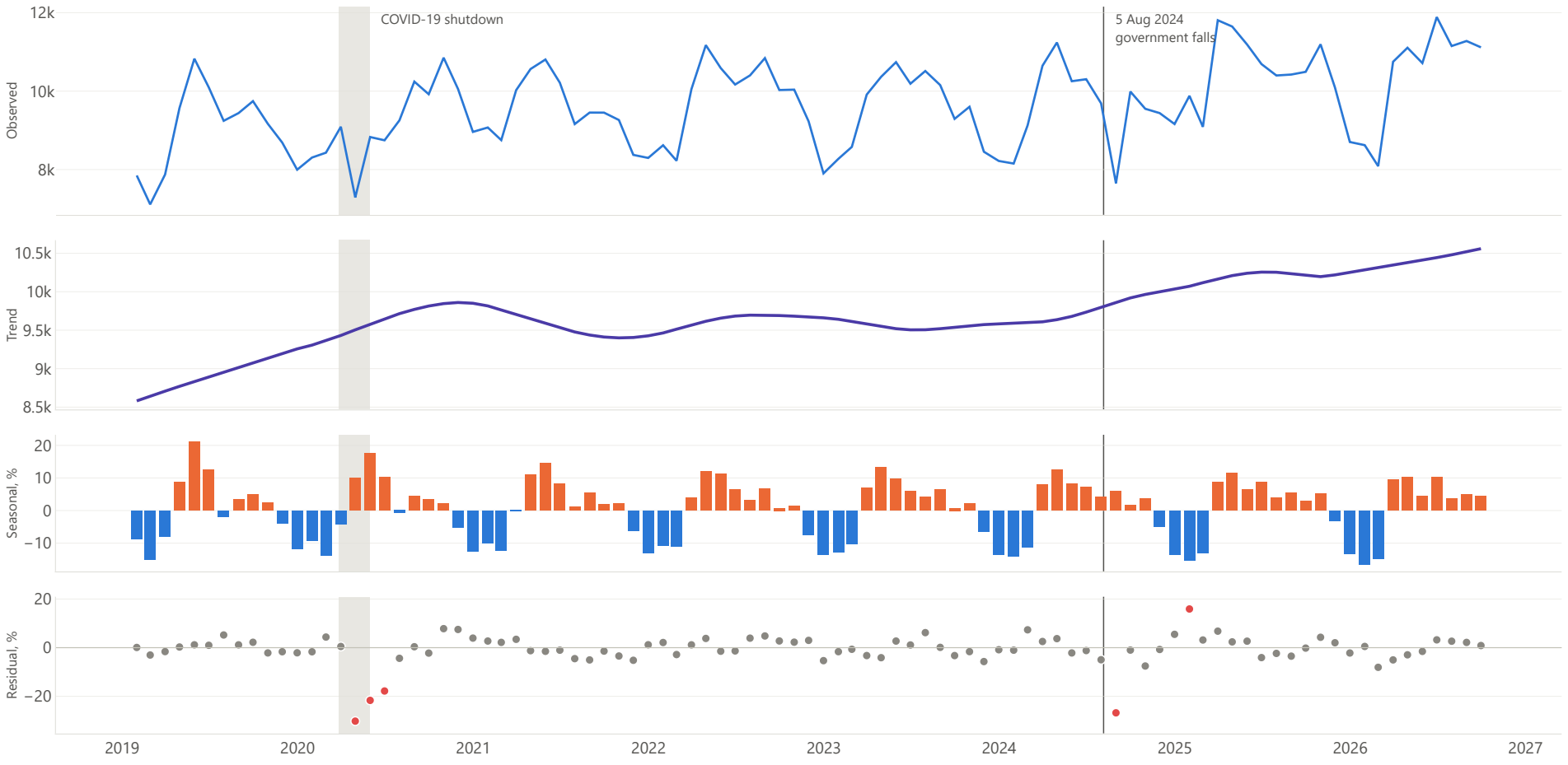


Chart data (CSV)

Which crimes move together? Burglary, robbery, dacoity, kidnapping and theft rise and fall together. Narcotics, smuggling and arms recoveries form a separate block that correlates *negatively* with robbery and dacoity: months with more police searches tend to be months with less violent property crime. Compare the periods before and after the break to see how the blocks changed.

Which crimes move together?

Spearman rank correlation of monthly national counts, ordered by hierarchical clustering of the whole period.

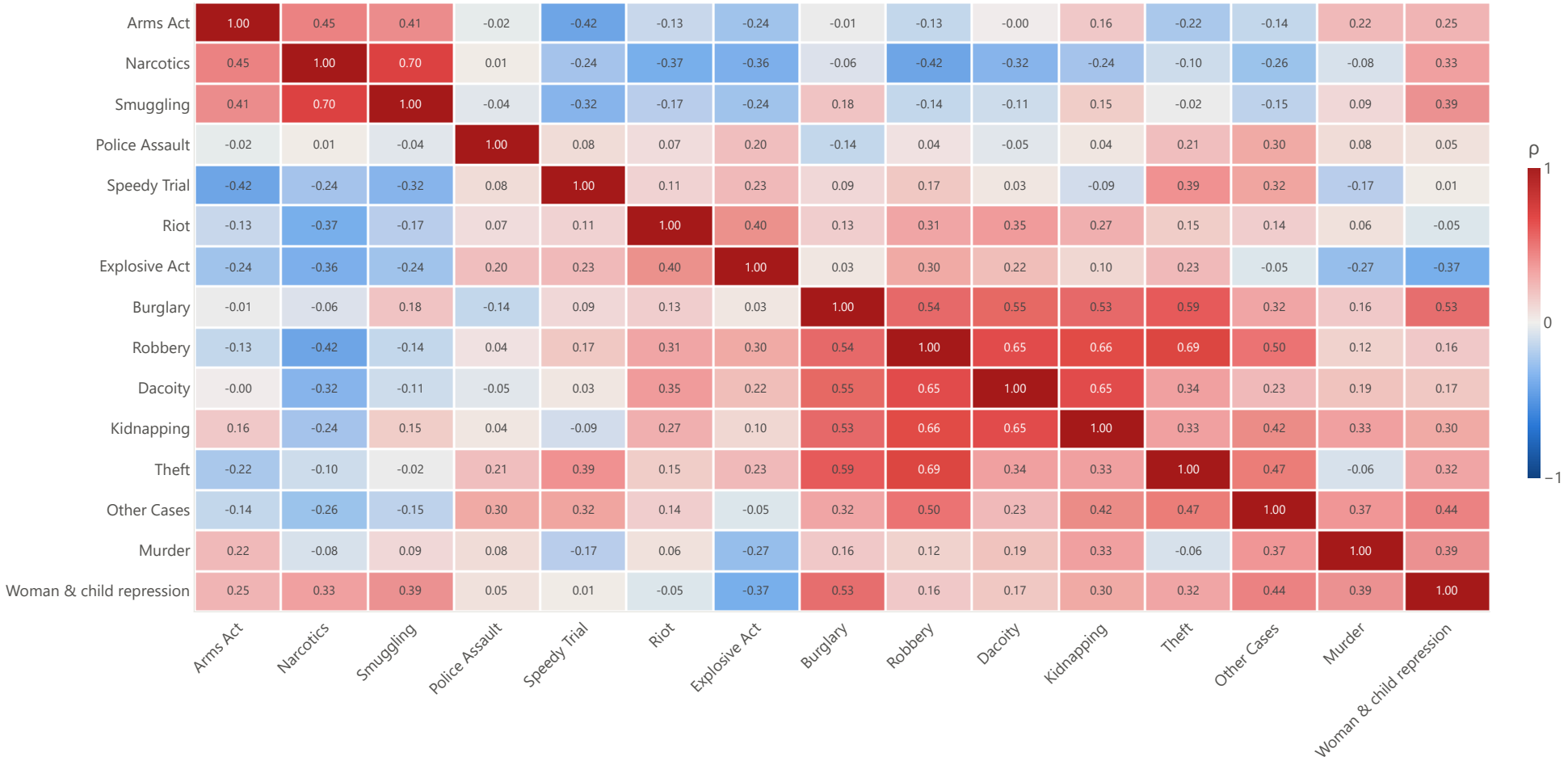


Chart data (CSV)

The pandemic pause

The lockdown showed what happens when policing and public life stop at the same time: almost everything recorded falls.

On 26 March 2020 the government closed offices, markets and transport for a nationwide “general holiday”, Bangladesh's COVID-19 lockdown. It lasted until 30 May. Recorded cases fell from 17,150 in March to 9,098 in April, 55% fewer than in April 2019. The two families of cases fell by very different amounts. Recovery cases, which come from police searches, fell 83% because officers were redeployed to enforce the lockdown. Reported crime, which depends on victims coming forward, fell 24%.

What stopped during the lockdown, and what came back

Change in cases against the same months of 2019. Filled dot: April–May 2020, the general holiday; open dot: July–September 2020, after reopening. Riot, explosives and speedy-trial cases are left out: too few or too erratic in 2019 to compare.

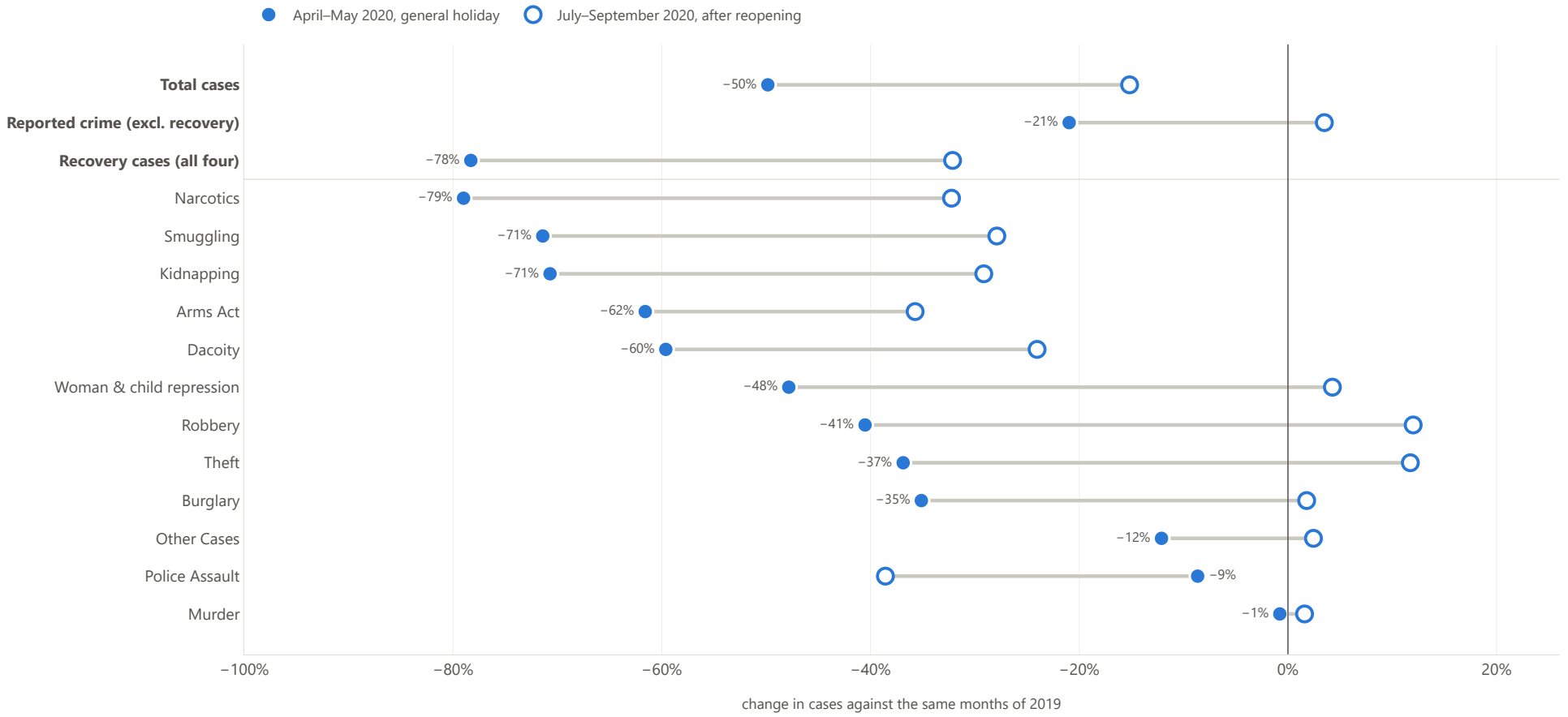


Chart data (CSV)

Crimes that need people on the move fell furthest. Against April and May 2019, kidnapping fell 71%, dacoity 60% and robbery 41%. With families at home, theft fell 37% and burglary 35%. Woman and child repression fell 48%, more likely because victims could not reach a police station than because the abuse stopped. Murder hardly moved (−1%): a killing gets recorded, lockdown or not.

The pause was short. Reported crime was back at its 2019 level by July 2020, and July–September 2020 was up 3% on the same months of 2019. Recovery cases came back more slowly: from July to December 2020 they ran at 72% of their 2019 level. The second-wave lockdowns of April and July 2021 pushed them down again, to 54% of the 2019 level both times, while reported crime held at 110% and 99%.

That makes 2020 a useful control: a collapse followed by a quick rebound is what a temporary pause looks like. August 2024 looks different. In their first month the two shocks look alike: recorded cases fell to 45% of normal in April 2020 and to 50% in August 2024, and recovery cases to 17% and 16%. Then they part ways. Over the two years after April 2020, dacoity, robbery and kidnapping ran at 98% of their 2019 level: back to normal. Over the two years after August 2024 they ran at 177% of their 2023 level.

Two shocks: a pause in 2020, a break in 2024

Monthly cases as a % of the same month in the last normal year: 2019 for the pandemic, 2023 for the 2024 break (100% = normal). Month 0 = April 2020 and August 2024. Shaded: the 2020 general holiday.

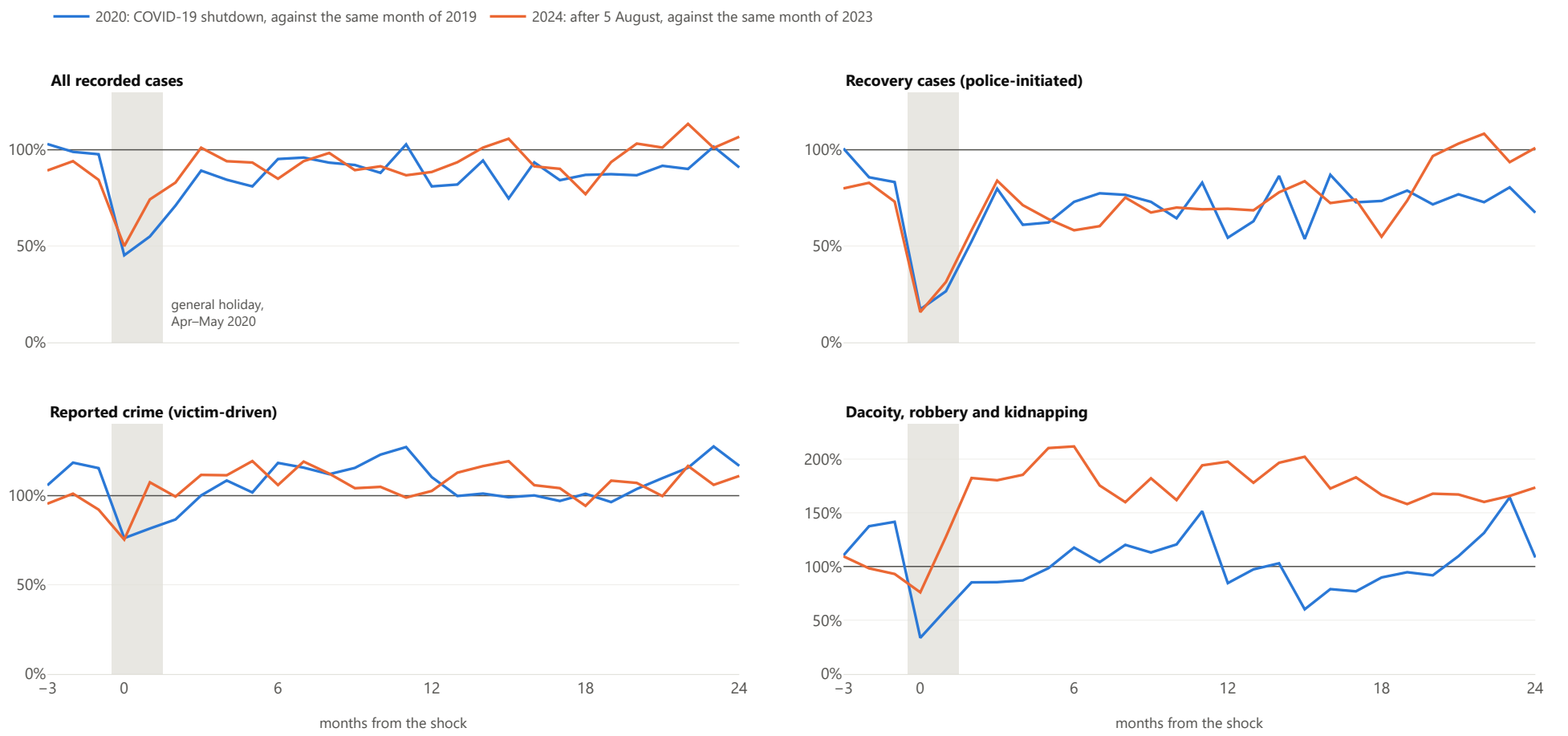


Chart data (CSV)

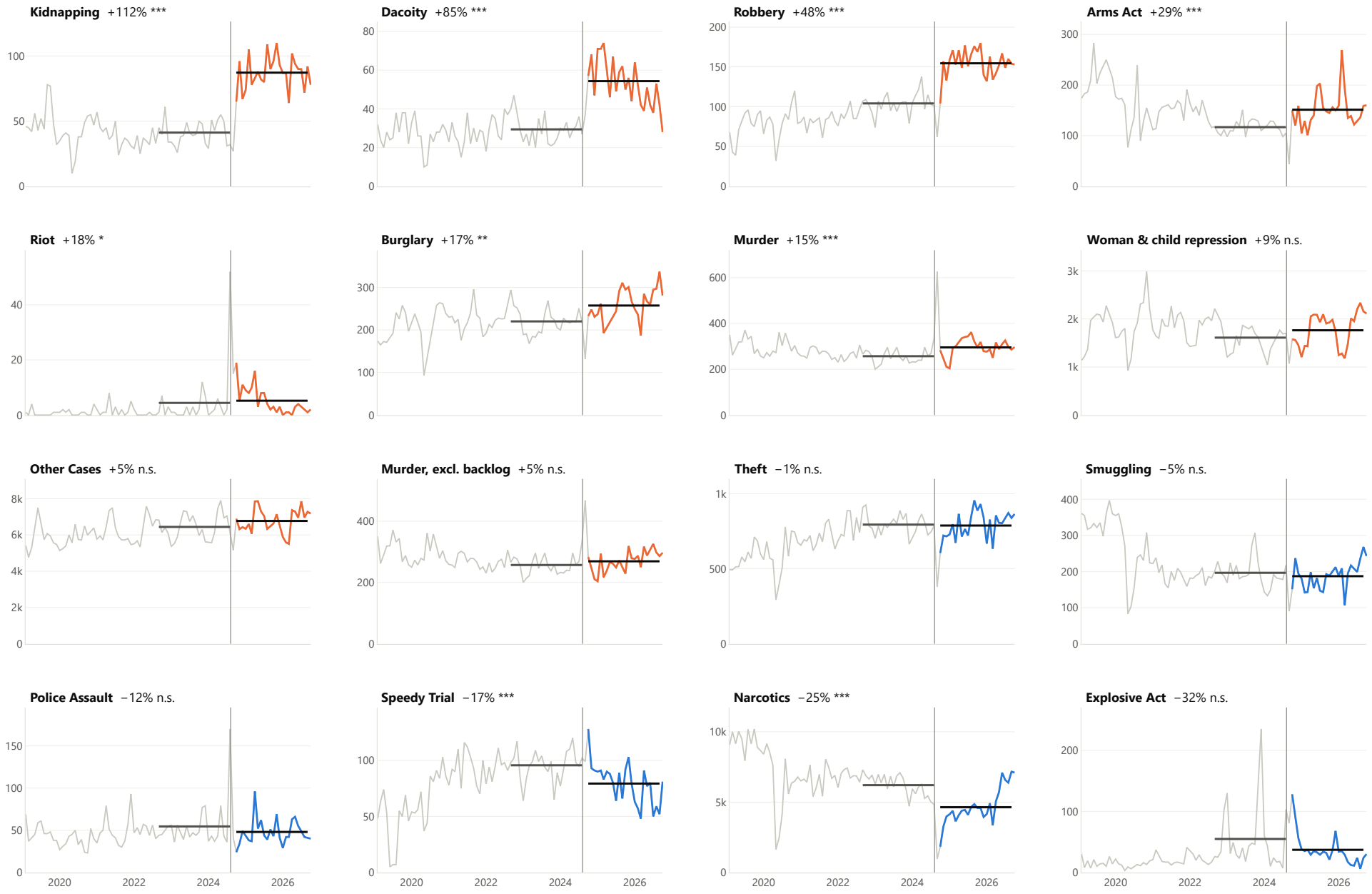
Rupture: after the fifth of August

In July 2024 the protests appeared in the data as riots and assaults on police. In August, the recording system itself broke. When it came back, the country's crime mix had changed.

July 2024 recorded 52 riot cases and 170 police-assault cases, both the highest in the series. Then, after 5 August, recorded cases fell 41.0% in one month, to 8,833. Narcotics recovery fell from 4,852 to 966 cases, yet murder cases jumped to 626, the highest monthly figure on record. Each panel below shows one crime head with its 24-month mean before and after the break.

Sixteen crime heads, one break

Monthly national cases. Bars: mean of the 24 months before (Aug 2022 – Jul 2024) and after (Sep 2024 – Aug 2026). % = change in means; stars = Mann–Whitney p (*** < 0.001). Orange = rose, blue = fell.



The before-and-after ledger adds uncertainty. Kidnapping more than doubled (+111.5%), from 41 to 87 cases a month; its Cliff's δ of 1.00 means every one of the 24 months after the break exceeded every one of the 24 months before. Dacoity rose +84.7% and robbery +48.4%. Arms Act cases rose +29.4%; narcotics fell −25.3%.

The before-and-after ledger

Point: % change in mean monthly cases; bar: bootstrap 95% CI of the ratio. Grey: CI crosses zero. August 2024 itself excluded.

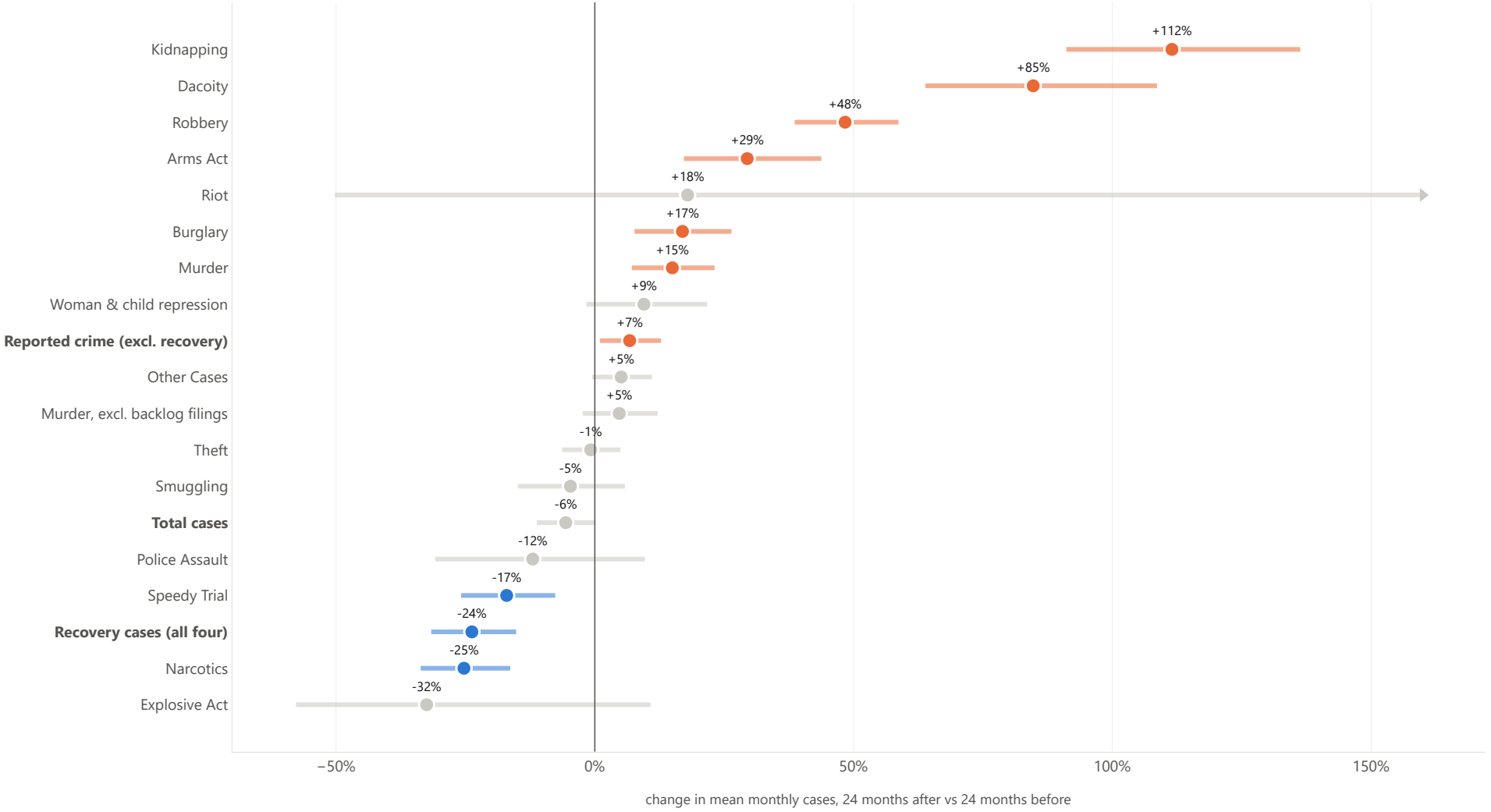


Chart data (CSV)

Was it the break, or the trend? Segmented negative-binomial models control for the pre-existing trend, the season and the COVID months. They still find large immediate level changes: ×2.22 for kidnapping (95% CI 1.90–2.61), ×2.39 for dacoity (2.05–2.79) and ×1.36 for robbery (1.22–1.51). For narcotics the level dropped to ×0.57.

Counting the gap: what the model expected without the break

log E[cases] = trend + post-break level + post-break slope + month effects + COVID and Aug-2024 dummies. Shaded: modelled excess (orange) or shortfall (blue) against the no-break counterfactual.

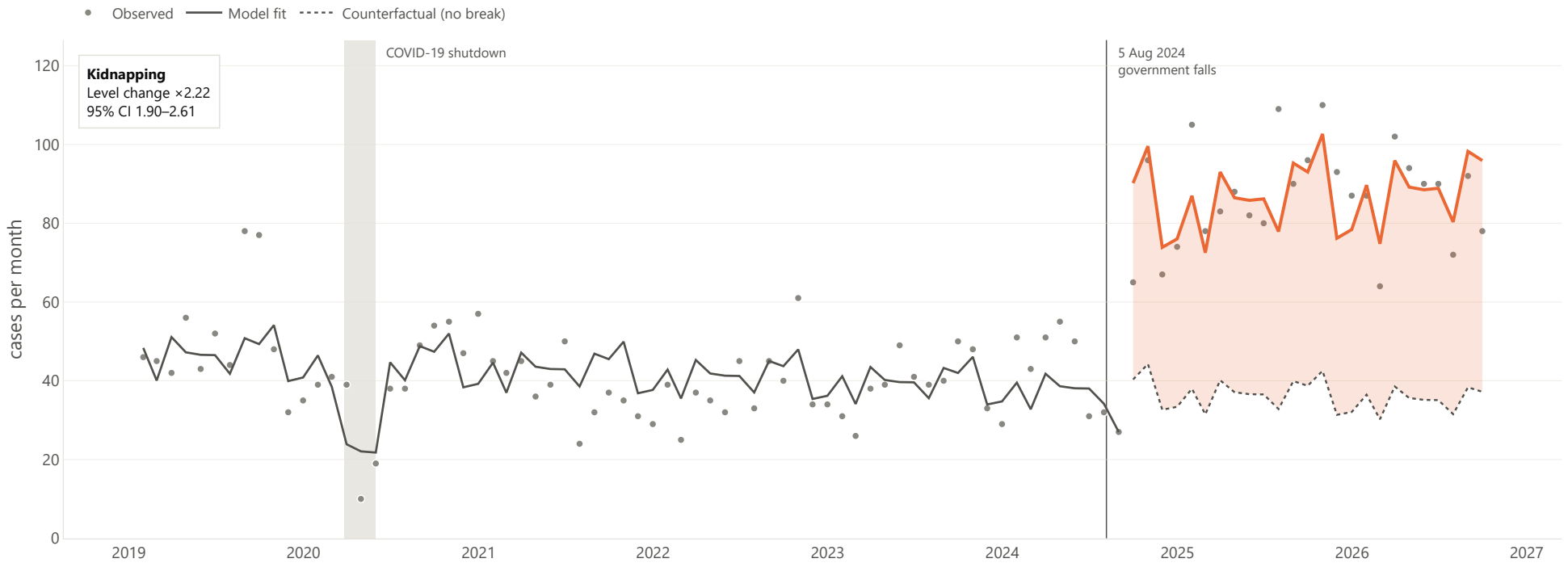


Chart data (CSV)

Two unsupervised methods agree on the timing without being told where to look. PELT places change points for dacoity in September 2024, kidnapping in September 2024 and robbery in October 2024. Isolation Forest flags Apr 2020, Aug 2024, May 2020, Sep 2024, May 2019, Feb 2019 as the most unusual months.

Machines agree with history

Top: Isolation Forest anomaly score of each month's 15-head crime mix (red = flagged, contamination 6%). Bottom: PELT change points (RBF cost) per series.

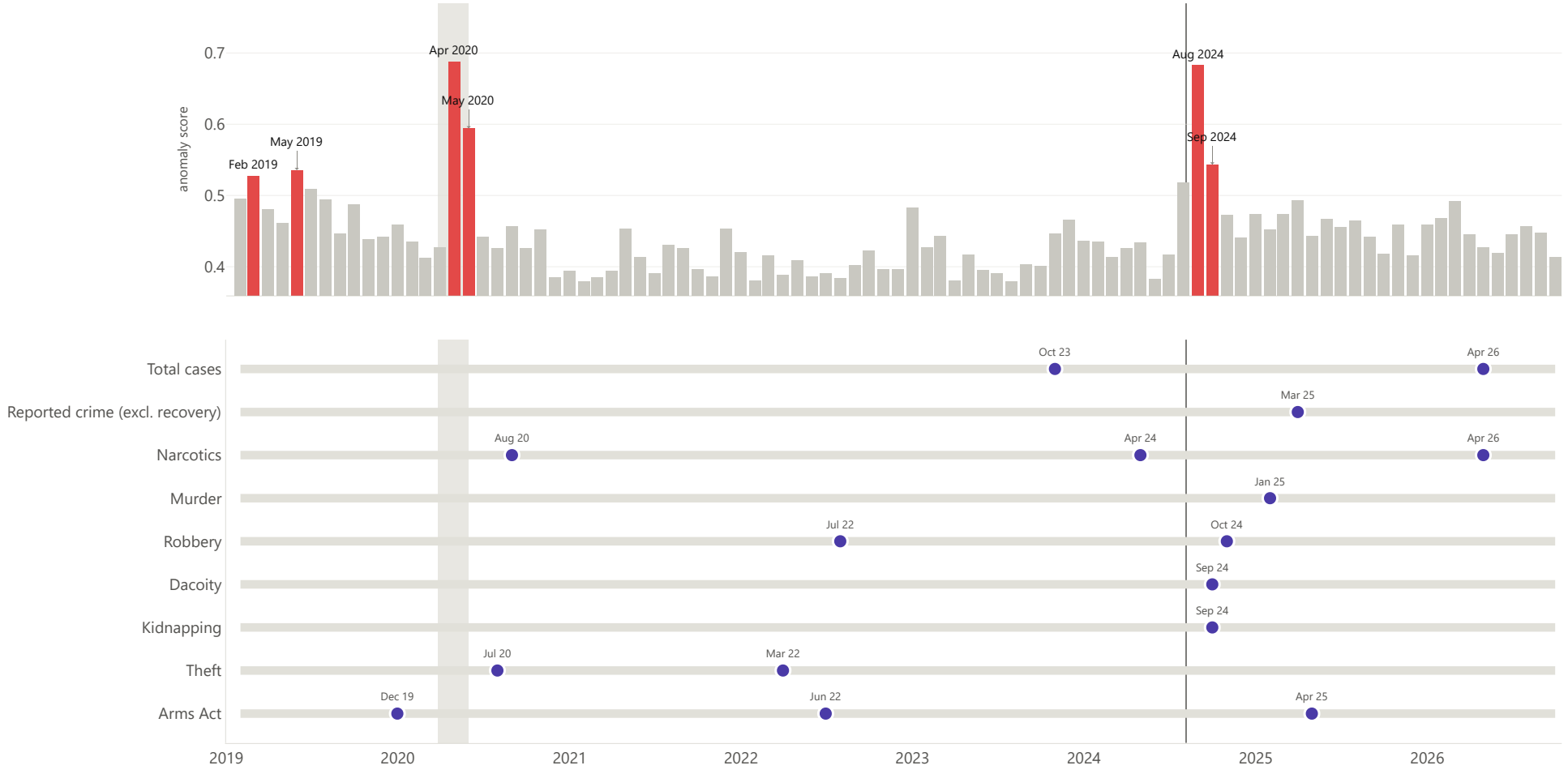


Chart data (CSV)

Murder needs care. Footnotes on the scans say 158 of August 2024's 626 murder cases were for killings between 2009 and July 2024 that families had not been able to file; similar notes appear every month from February to September 2025, 791 backlog cases in all. Remove them and the picture changes: raw murder is up +15.0%, but murder excluding backlog filings is up only +4.7% (Mann–Whitney p = 0.18), with a model level change of ×0.99 (95% CI 0.92–1.08).

The murder spike is partly a paperwork spike

Monthly murder cases split by the footnotes that count delayed filings for older killings.

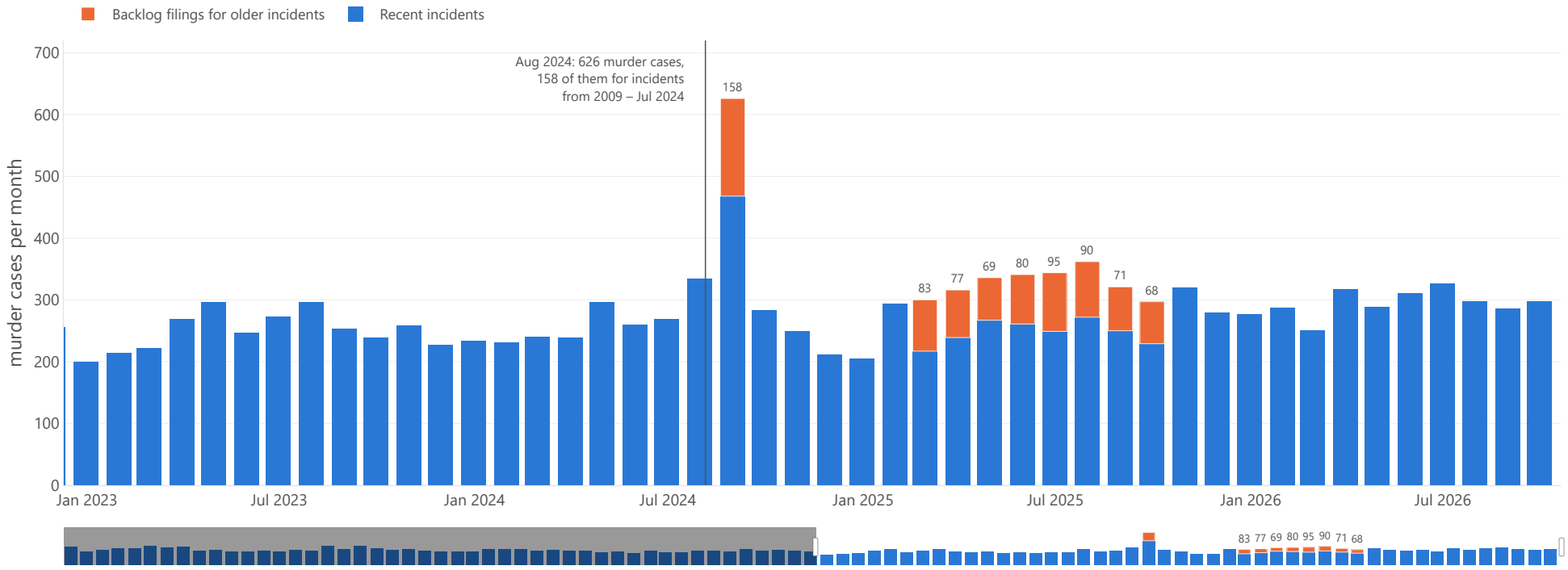


Chart data (CSV)

Violent property crime moved to a new normal. From 2019 to 2023 the median month saw between 146 and 172 dacoity, robbery and kidnapping cases; in 2025 the median was 314.

Violent property crime shifted right, and stayed there

Distribution of monthly national cases by year (density; ticks = individual months). 2026 = Jan–Sep.

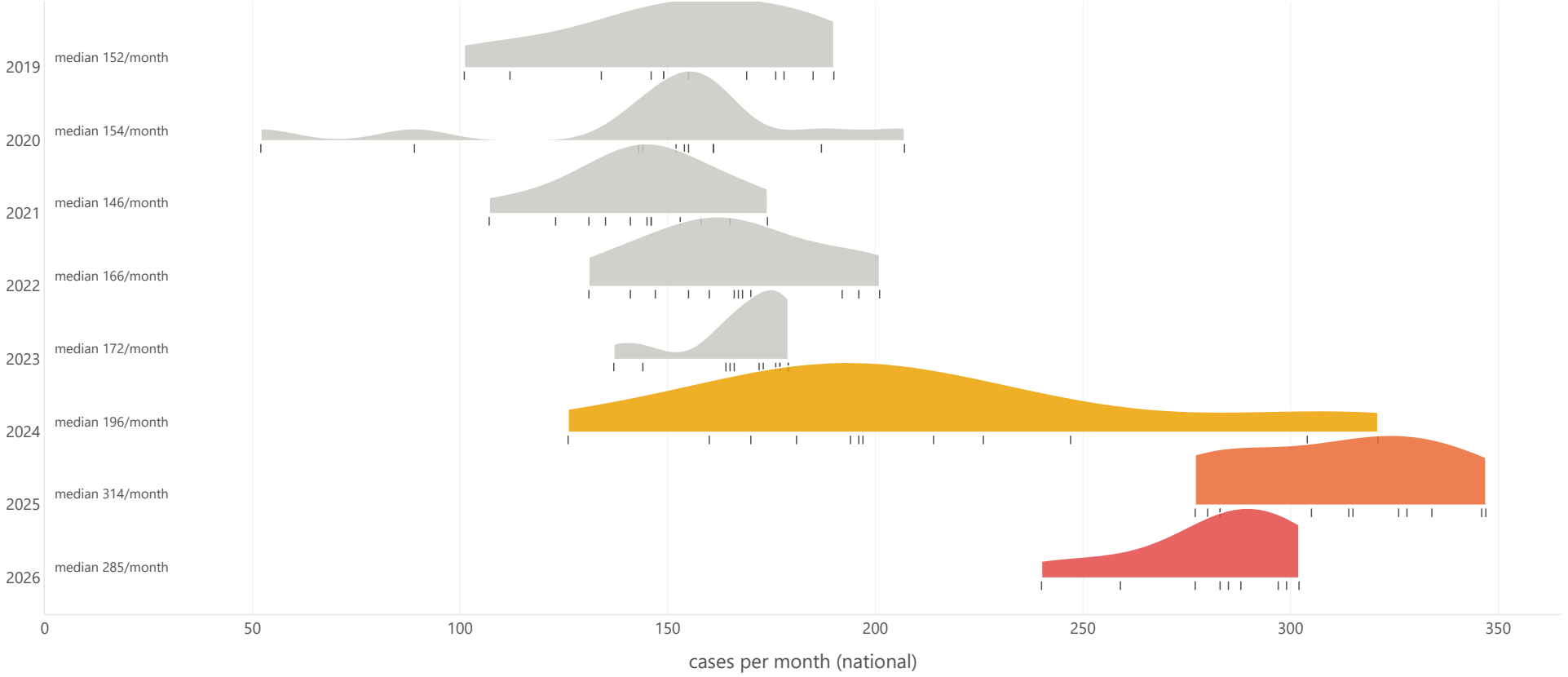


Chart data (CSV)

The mix shifts: violent property crime claims a larger slice

Share of the ten named reactive crime heads (excludes “other cases” and recovery cases), 3-month rolling mean.

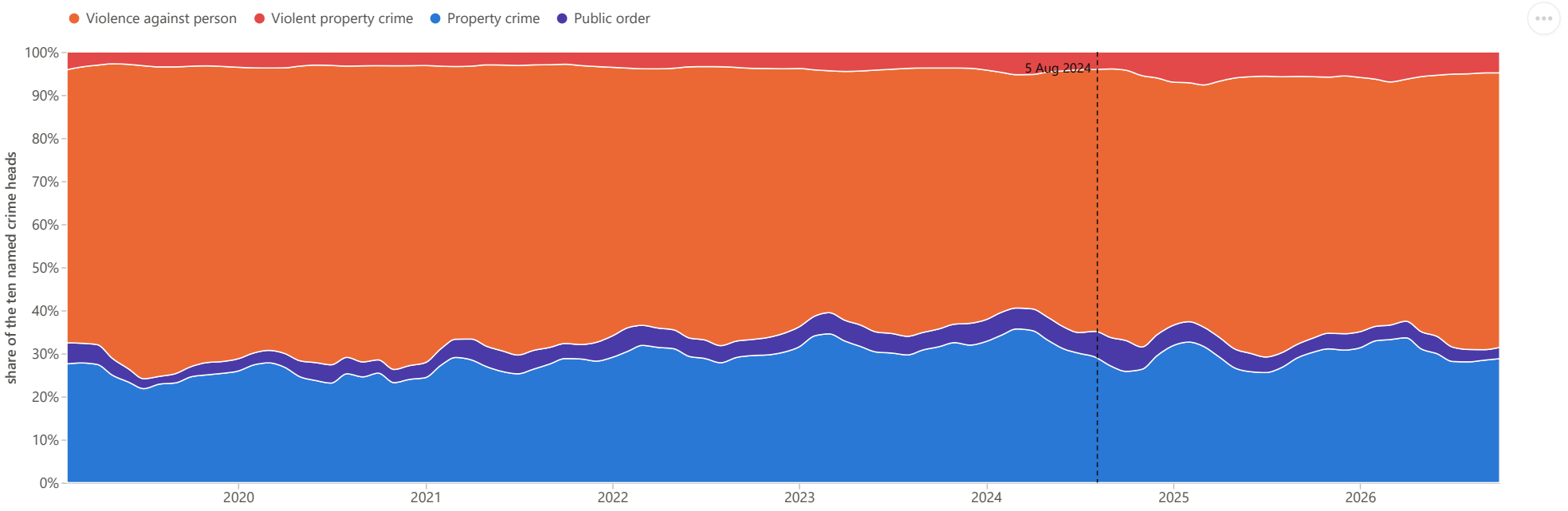


Chart data (CSV)

Year against year

Change in national annual cases by crime head. Default: 2025, the first full year after the break, against 2023, the last full year before it.

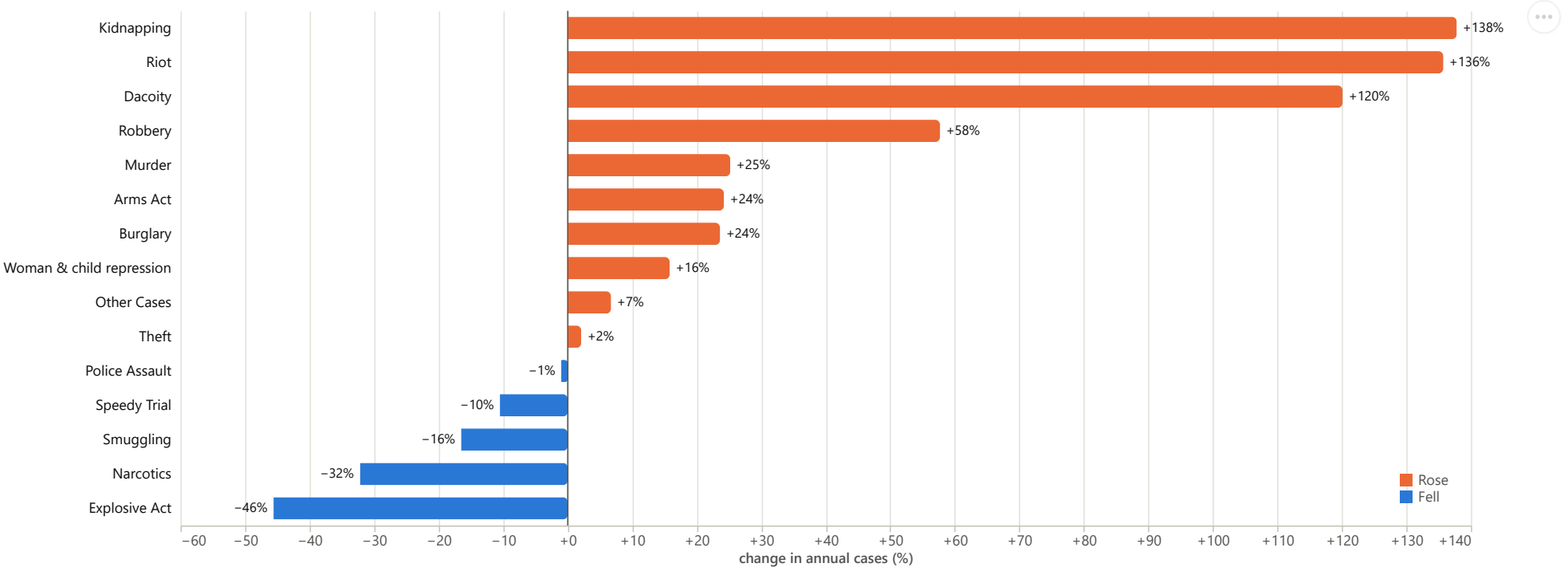


Chart data (CSV)

The geography of the break

The rise in violent crime reached every part of the country, but not equally.

Police units are grouped into the eight census divisions (each metro unit with its range) and divided by population. In 2025 reported crime per person was highest in Barishal (109 per 100,000) and lowest in Mymensingh (58) and Chattogram (64). The change in violent crime is a different map: +68% in Barishal, +59% in Khulna, +51% in Dhaka, against +11% in Mymensingh, +17% in Rangpur.

Where crime is reported

Reported crime per 100,000 people per year, by division.

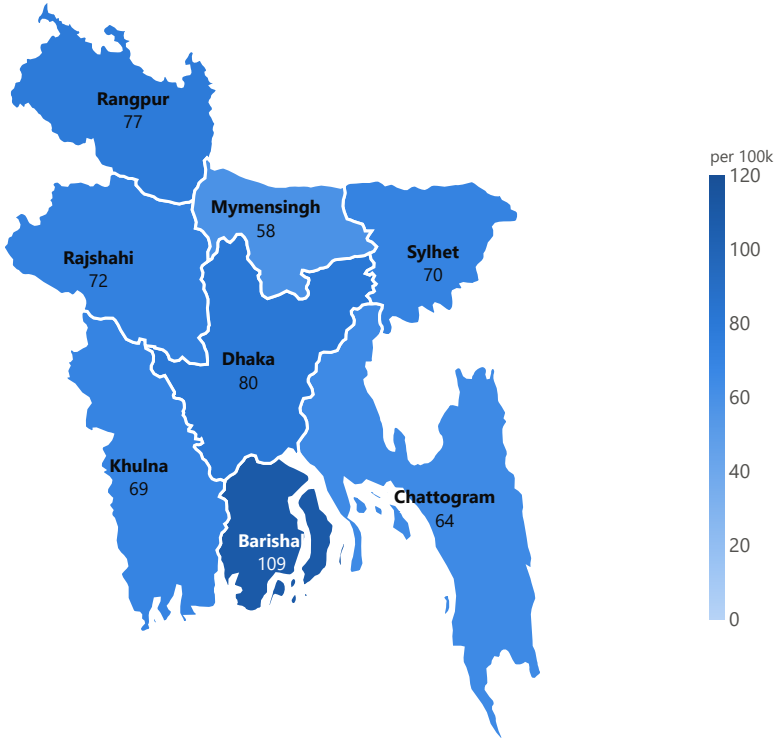


Chart data (CSV)

Where violence grew

Change in mean monthly cases, 24 months after vs 24 months before August 2024.

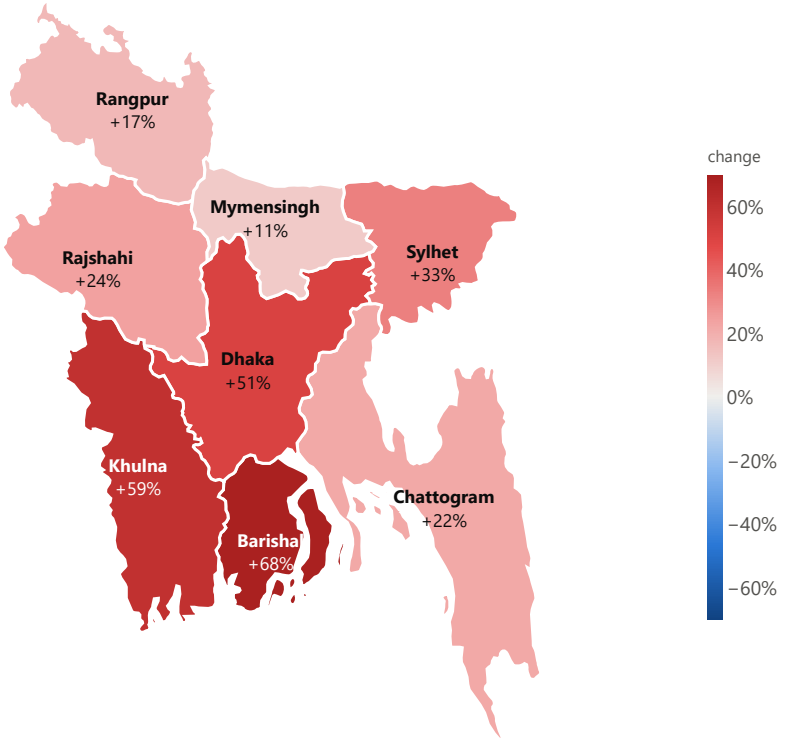


Chart data (CSV)

16 of the 17 police units recorded more violent crime after the break; the exception is CMP (+0%, essentially flat). In relative terms the biggest rises were KMP (+138%), BMP (+115%), DMP (+108%).

Nearly every unit saw more violent crime after the break

Mean monthly cases, 24 months before vs 24 months after August 2024 (log scale).

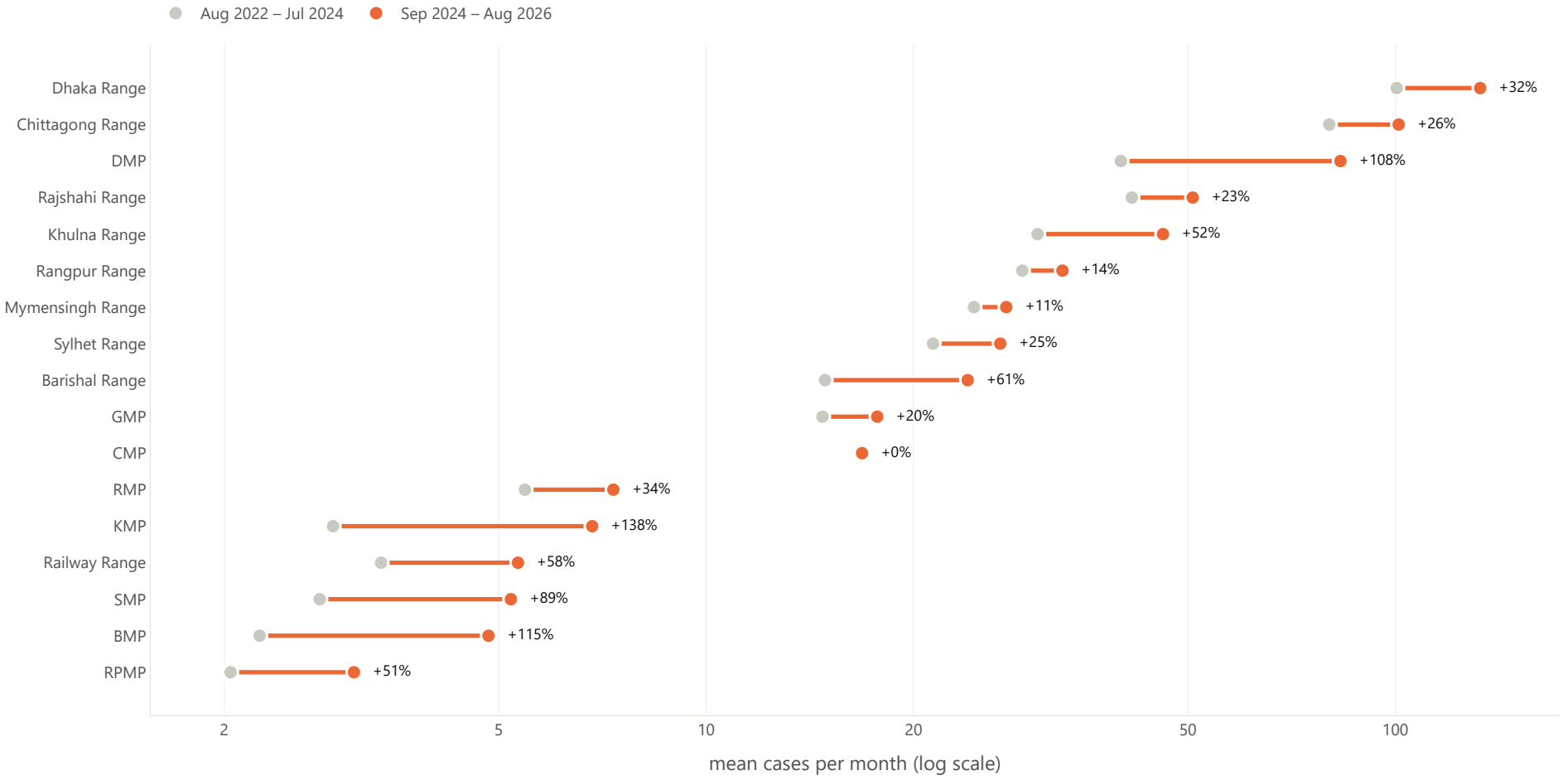


Chart data (CSV)

Where the break hit: change by police unit and crime head

Mean monthly cases Sep 2024 – Aug 2026 against Aug 2022 – Jul 2024. Red = rise, blue = fall (colour capped at +200%). Lines separate metro, range and railway police.

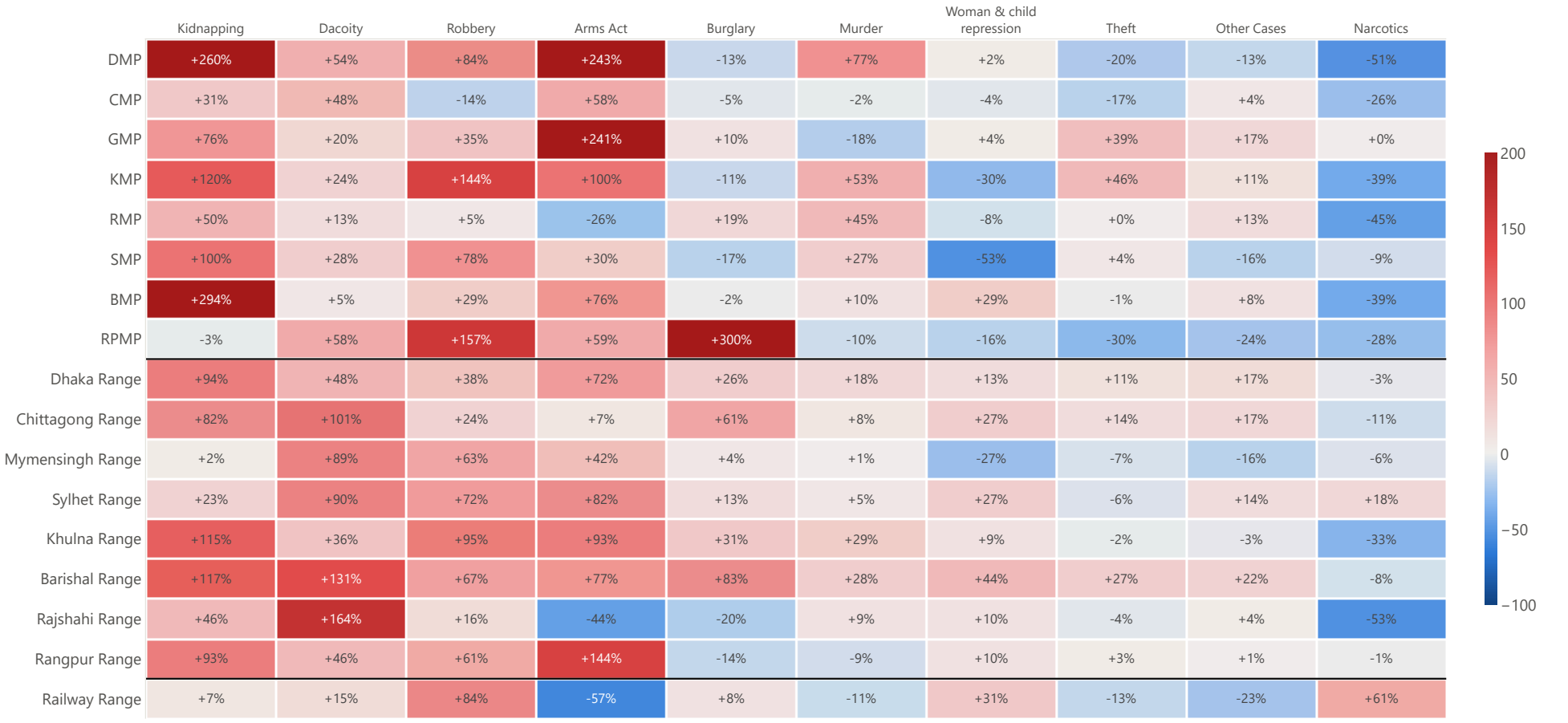


Chart data (CSV)

Ranked by reported crime, the large district ranges lead. Chittagong Range and Dhaka Range hold the top two places in every year. Hover a line to follow one unit; the animated race below replays the same ranking year by year.

Who reports the most crime?

Rank of the 16 territorial units by annual reported crime (total minus recovery cases). Highlighted: DMP and the three biggest movers. *2026 annualised from Jan–Sep.

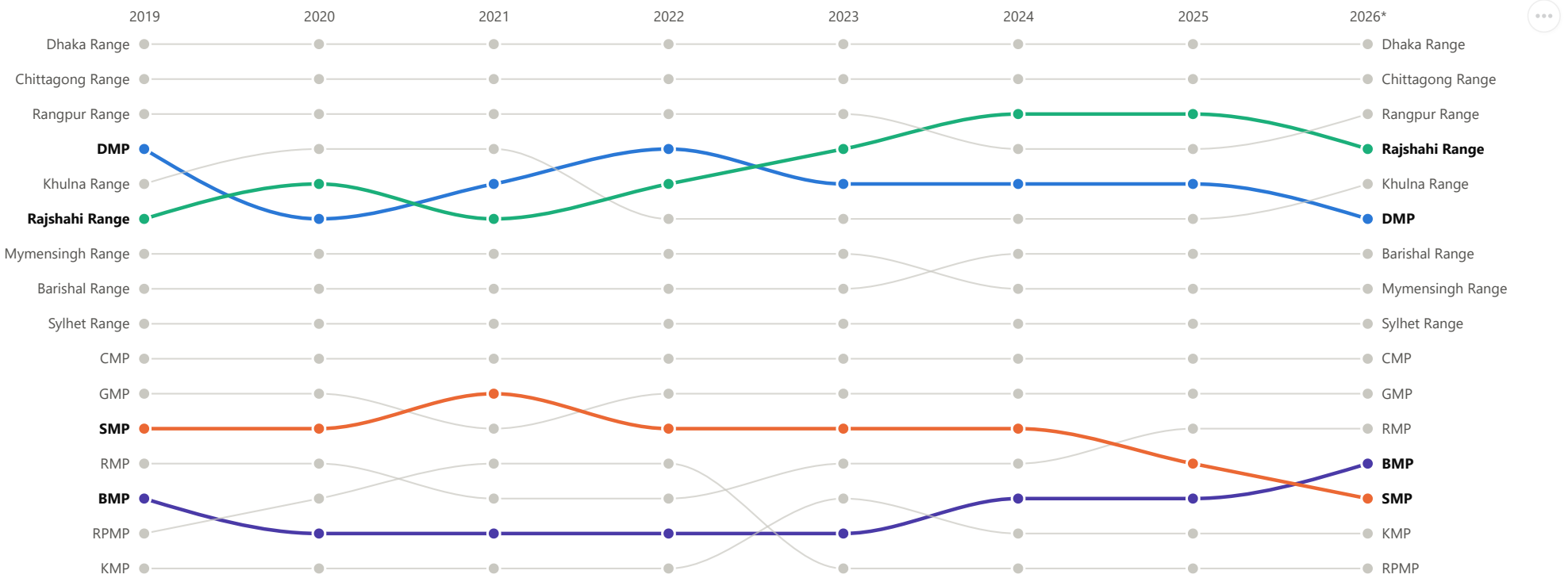


Chart data (CSV)

Reported crime by police unit, year by year

Annual reported crime per unit; 2026 annualised from January–September. Blue: metropolitan police; orange: range police.

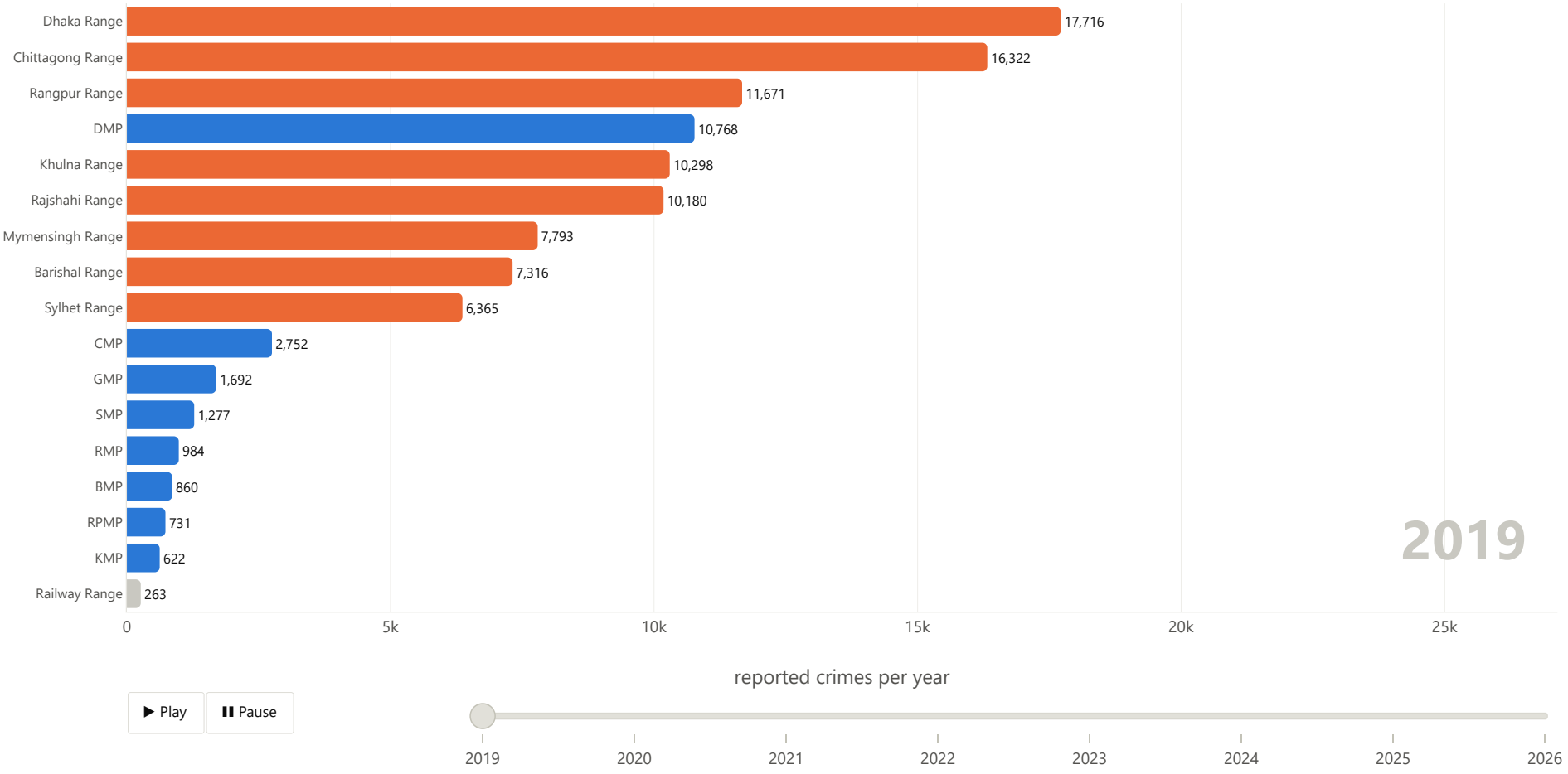


Chart data (CSV)

Clustering the units by the *mix* of their caseload, not its size, gives three groups. The **metro and port belt** (CMP, Chittagong Range, DMP, KMP, Khulna Range, RMP, SMP) over-indexes on narcotics, arms, robbery and burglary. The **northern agrarian ranges** (Mymensingh Range, Rajshahi Range, Rangpur Range, Sylhet Range) over-index on smuggling, consistent with their long land border. The **Dhaka–Barishal ring** (BMP, Barishal Range, Dhaka Range, GMP, RPMP) over-indexes on dacoity and kidnapping. The two PCA axes explain 71% of the variation; a silhouette of 0.26 says these are tendencies rather than sharp borders.

Three crime signatures

PCA of each unit's 2019–2026 crime mix (centred log-ratio of 15 head shares), coloured by k-means cluster (k = 3). Arrows: the eight heads that load most.

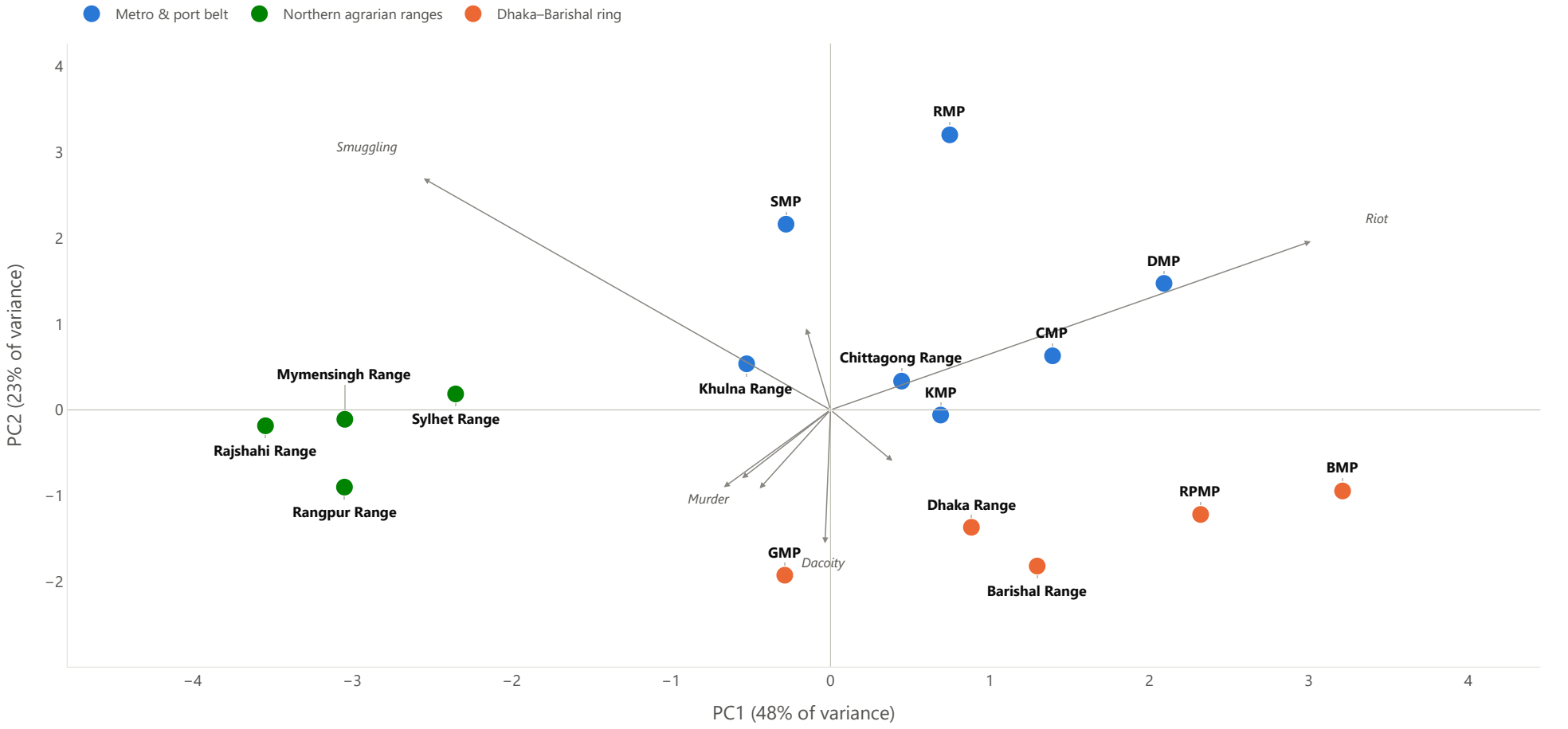


Chart data (CSV)

Three signatures, side by side

Share of each crime head in the cluster's caseload, indexed to the average unit (= 100).

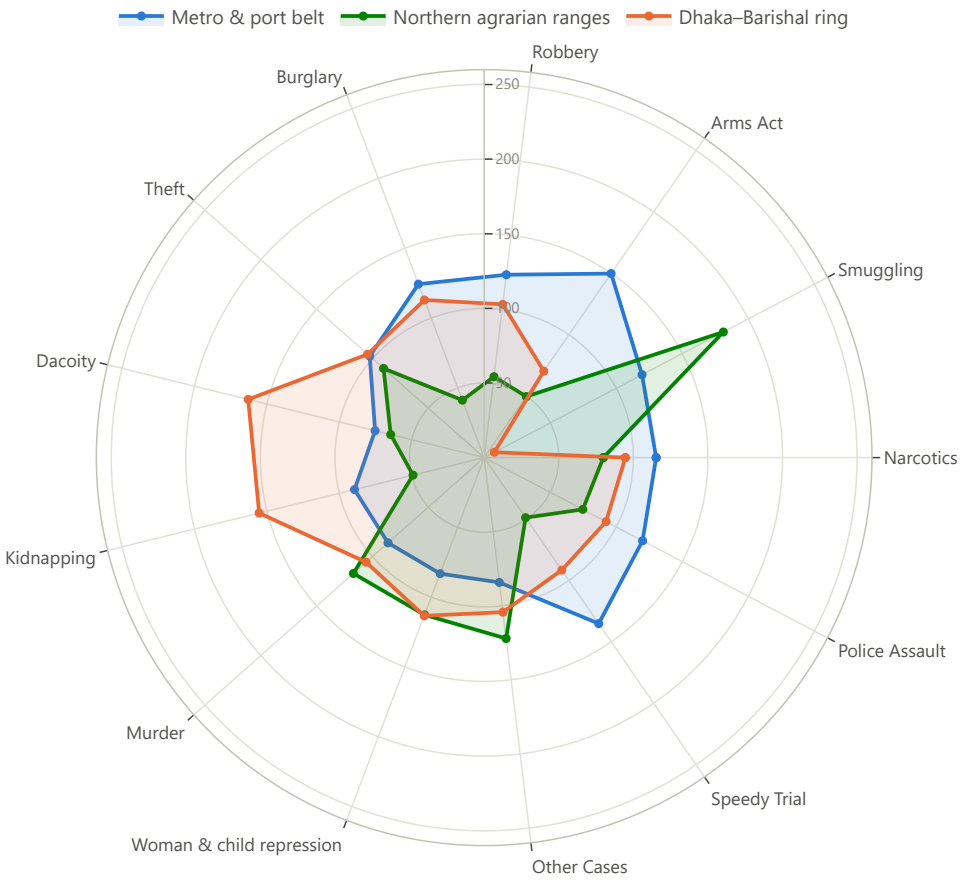


Chart data (CSV)

A slow return?

Searches and seizures are rising again and violent crime is easing, but not yet back to where it was.

Comparing January–September 2026 with the same months of 2025, recovery cases are up 34.6%, driven by narcotics (+36.4%): the strongest sign yet that proactive policing is returning, in the year of the 12 February 2026 general election. At the same time dacoity is down 28.1%, murder down 8.7% and robbery down 7.3%.

January–September 2026 against January–September 2025, national cases

Series	Jan–Sep 2025	Jan–Sep 2026	Change
Total cases	137,870	151,596	+10.0%
Reported crime (excl. recovery)	95,616	94,711	−0.9%
Recovery cases	42,254	56,885	+34.6%
of which narcotics	39,129	53,372	+36.4%
Murder	2,911	2,659	−8.7%
Dacoity	538	387	−28.1%
Robbery	1,483	1,374	−7.3%
Kidnapping	811	769	−5.2%

Overview and detail

Monthly national cases. Drag across the lower strip to choose the period shown above.

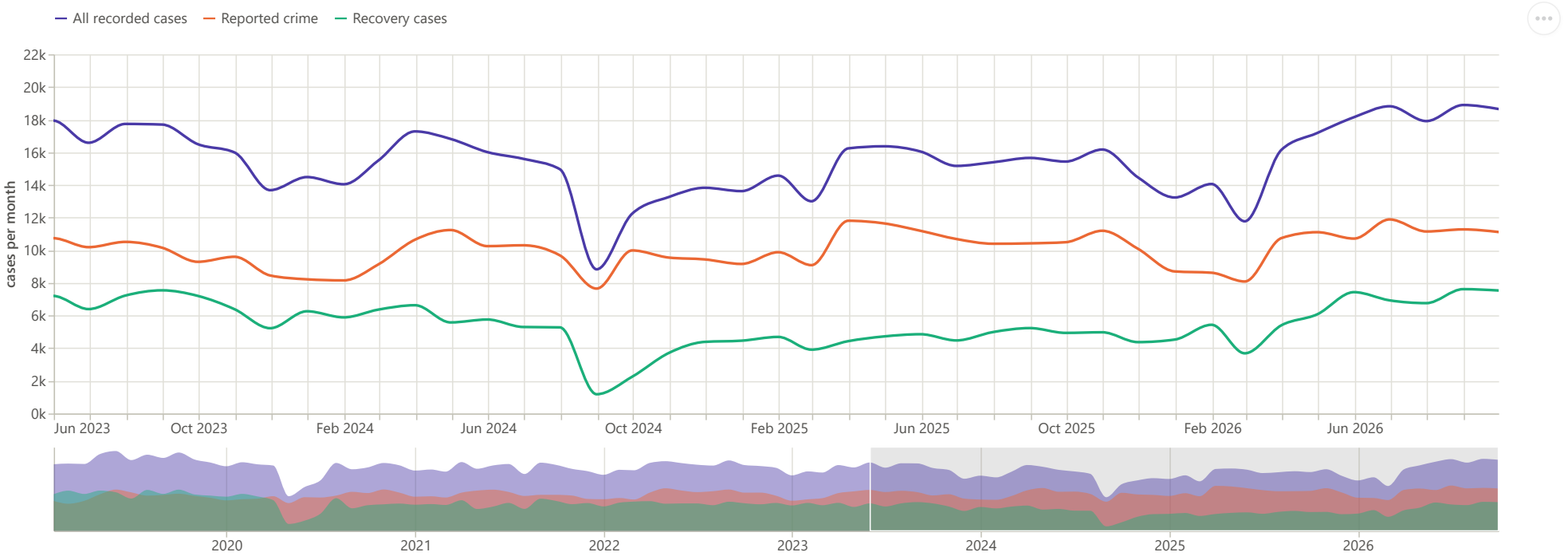


Chart data (CSV)

SARIMAX models on log counts, with a regime dummy for the break and Fourier terms for the season, forecast 190,474 cases from October 2026 to September 2027 (last 12 months: 195,463). Walk-forward backtests over the last 12 observed months beat a seasonal-naive forecast for every series: total cases 8.4% mean absolute percentage error against 10.3%, reported crime 5.6% against 8.5%.

What the next twelve months may hold

SARIMAX forecast with 80% and 95% intervals; orange: walk-forward one-step forecasts for the last 12 observed months.

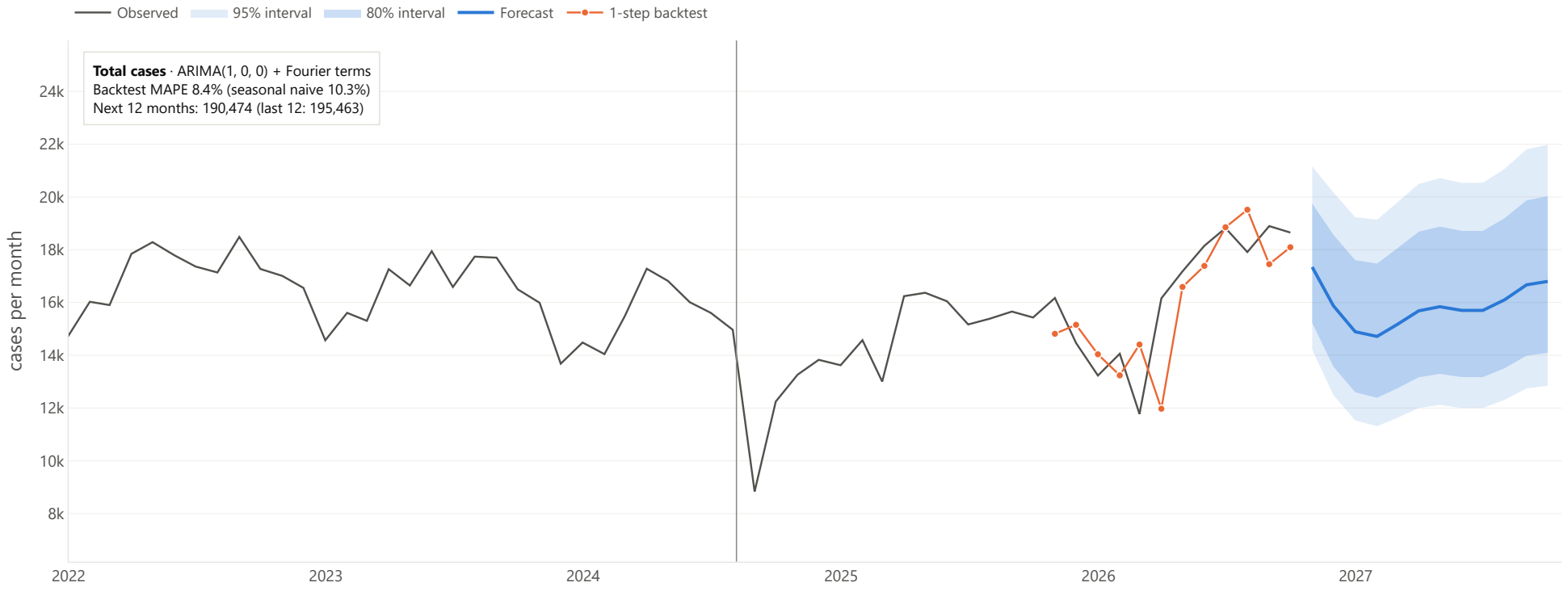


Chart data (CSV)

About the data

The story uses the monthly crime statistics of Bangladesh Police Headquarters, January 2019 – September 2026. The 28 published PDF files were digitised and merged into one table of 1,581 rows (93 months × 17 police units), each row tagged with the last day of its month (for example 30 Jun 2025). National figures are the sum of the 17 units. These are cases recorded by police, not all crimes committed.

Dataset	Details	Link
Crime statistics	Bangladesh Police Headquarters: cases by police unit and crime head, published every month as scanned PDF tables	police.gov.bd
Merged dataset	All 93 months in one Excel sheet, with the source PDF of each month and the translated table footnotes	Excel file
Original PDFs	The 28 files as downloaded from police.gov.bd	GitHub
Population	BBS Population and Housing Census 2022, adjusted figures by division, for the rates per 100,000 people	The Business Standard
Division boundaries	geoBoundaries, Bangladesh ADM1 (CC0), for the maps	geoboundaries.org

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